

Philosophy and Islam



Following its foundation by Mohammed in the seventh century, Islam spread rapidly from Arabia into Asia, across northern Africa and even to southern Spain. The Islamic Empire rivalled Christian Europe in size and influence, and its stability produced a flourishing culture. The Islamic 'Golden Age' began around 750 CE and lasted for more than five centuries. Islam encouraged scholarship and, unlike the Christianity of the time, recognized that religion and rational enquiry could exist side by side.

Islamic scholars, often polymaths educated in science and philosophy as well as theology, preserved and translated Greek texts (most notably the

works of Aristotle), but also scientific and mathematical works from India. As a result, scholars made advances in fields such as astronomy, medicine, mathematics and alchemy that would not have been possible in the Christian world. A distinctive Islamic 'school' of philosophy evolved, and two great figures, Avicenna and Averroes, incorporated the ideas of Plato and Aristotle into Islamic theology.